



NON-NATIVE SPEAKERS' PERCEPTIONS OF THE INTELLIGIBILITY OF TURKISH IN TURKEY

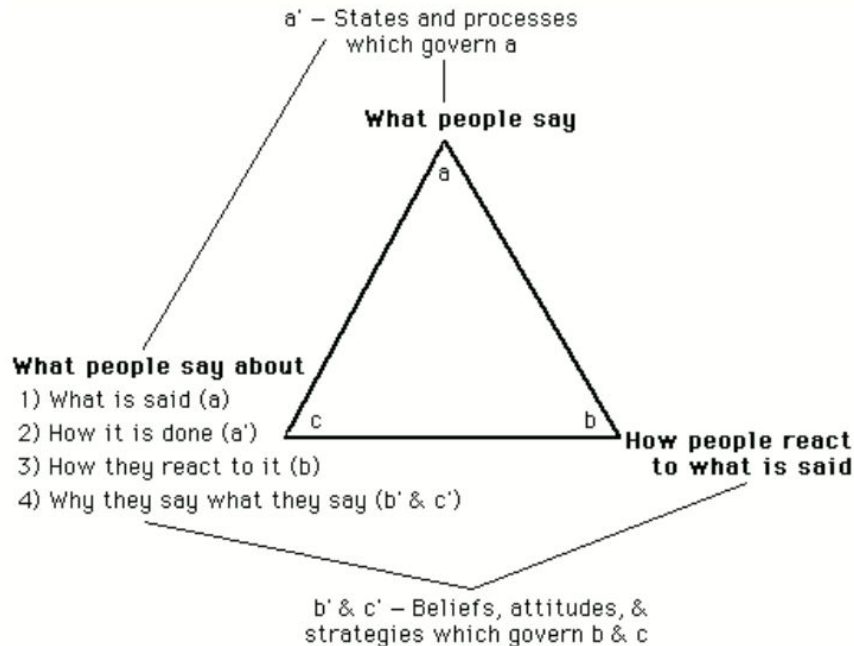
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Background Literature



Perceptual dialectology:

- how non-linguists perceive the distribution of language varieties in their own and surrounding communities;
- what beliefs and values of theirs lead them to these perceptions (Preston, 1999)



Background Literature (Cont'd)

Smith & Nelson's (1985) study investigating the perceptions of varieties of English by non-native speakers:

- *intelligibility*: word / utterance recognition
- *comprehensibility*: word / utterance meaning
- *interpretability*: meaning behind word / utterance

Recordings of nine varieties of English listened by native, non-native, and mixed groups



Background Literature (Cont'd)

Results:

- Mean scores: intelligibility > comprehensibility > interpretability
- Familiarity with the topic X
- Familiarity with the variety V
- Standard variety -> perceived as more educated
- native speakers -> not the highest scores regarding how well they were understood



Background Literature (Cont'd)

Studies on varieties of Turkish

- Istanbul Turkish as the standard spoken variety of modern Turkish ? (Uğur, 2002; Gedik, 2003; Söylemez, 2004)
- Demirci and Kleiner's (1999) study on the perception of Turkish dialects in Turkey
 - Western cities as more correct, more pleasant, and less different
 - Men providing and having higher scores for correctness and pleasantness
 - Middle-aged group providing the lowest scores



Our study

- **Focus:** to investigate *intelligibility* and *comprehensibility* of different dialects of Turkish to non-native speakers of Turkish residing in mainland Turkey
 - a dialect is considered to be intelligible when the utterances of that dialect can be recognized as words or phrases by the listeners,
 - a dialect is considered to be comprehensible when the utterances of that dialect represent meaningful units in the given language and can be understood by the listeners.
- **Paradigm:** interpretivist
- **Method:** qualitative methods of data collection
- **Significance:** few studies on Turkish as an International Language (TIL) compared to English as a lingua franca



Research questions

1. How intelligible are different dialects to non-native speakers of Turkish residing in Turkey?
2. How comprehensible are different dialects to non-native speakers of Turkish residing in Turkey?
3. Which dialects do they commonly run into in daily life?
4. For which functions in different domains of language use do they use Turkish?



Participants

- Eight university students
- Two different Turkish-medium universities in the Marmara region
- History, International Trade, Medicine, Midwifery, Physiotherapy and Rehabilitation, and Sociology Departments
- Countries of the participants: Azerbaijan, Greece, Iran, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan
- Between the ages of 19-25
- Intermediate level of Turkish, at least 6 months of residence



Data collection & Analysis

- Mixed data collection techniques such as:
 - Questionnaires
 - Focus group interviews (Transcribed, coded and analyzed thematically)



Questionnaires

- took 5 minutes to complete
- language learning experiences with Turkish
- investigated use of Turkish in their daily life



Focus group interviews

- Short but authentic videos of four different dialects of Turkish; Aegean d., Black Sea d., East Anatolian d., and İstanbul d.
- Watching the videos one by one and talking about their intelligibility and comprehensibility through semi-structured interview questions



Results - Questionnaire data

1. Participants reported that they learnt Turkish through:
 - a. taking classes
 - b. being exposed to the language on TV, in Turkish movies, books and songs
2. The main reason to learn Turkish was *education (75%)* followed by *work, travel* and *social life*
3. They found it important to use the Turkish language with their friends and people around them to improve their language skills.
4. They regarded the accents of their interlocutors as peculiar and the speech rate as important in the comprehensibility of the messages.



Results - Interview data

1. All participants seemed to understand the gist of all videos presented to them..
2. In terms of intelligibility: İstanbul > Black Sea ≥ East Anatolian > Aegean
3. In terms of comprehensibility: İstanbul > East Anatolian ≥ Black Sea > Aegean
4. Participants have language awareness about different dialects spoken around them

“I think it is not İstanbul dialect. People in Turkey speak like the boy in East Anatolian video. Nobody speaks Turkish like exact Turkish. They don't say ‘geliyor musun’ but they say ‘geliyon mu’.”



Conclusion & Discussion

- Istanbul dialect as the most intelligible and comprehensible one -> high exposure, familiarity
 - unlike the case in US and UK English in Smith and Nelson's (1922) study
- Aegean dialect as the least intelligible and comprehensible one
- Factors leading to differing perceptions in comprehensibility and intelligibility:
 - geographical closeness of participants' home countries to the regions of the dialects; e.g. Uzbekistani participants finding Black Sea dialect more comprehensible
 - typological similarities; e.g. Azerbaijani participants having higher intelligibility and comprehensibility scores
 - place and duration of residence in Turkey; e.g. participant with 6 years of staying across different parts of Turkey finding East Anatolian dialect more common



Pedagogical Implications

- culture-and-dialect-integrated lessons
- culture-integrated sessions where students can gain experience with different dialects
- using teaching materials, such as videos or listening tracks, presenting different dialects
- slow-paced introduction to dialects



Limitations

- The number of the participants
- The native language background -> language proximity!



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